Essay 2 · the argument

DRAFT 1 · 14 February 2028 · 512 words

I think that it is probably important to note that a lot of people keep their phones next to their bed, and I used to be one of them, and honestly I think it was kind of a problem for me, so in this essay I want to argue that it's better to keep it somewhere else, like the kitchen.

The main reason people say they need their phone by the bed is in case of emergencies. I understand this. I used to think this too. But if you actually think about it, how many emergencies have there been? For me the answer is basically none. Most of the time when I picked up my phone in the night it was not because of an emergency, it was just because it was there, and then I would end up scrolling for a long time, sometimes like an hour, which obviously is not good for sleep.

In HUM 101 we read the part of the Odyssey with the Sirens, where Odysseus gets tied to the mast so he can hear them but not go to them. I think this is kind of a good metaphor for the phone situation. Basically he knew he would be weak so he set things up ahead of time so that his weakness would not matter. I think that's smart, and I think that's basically what putting your phone in the kitchen is. It's like tying yourself to the mast.

Since I started doing this I have noticed that I sleep better and I read more books. I also think I have more ideas in the morning, although it is hard to prove that. The morning check still happens but it's shorter because I'm standing up.

Some people might say what about emergencies, and I did have one, when my mom went to the hospital. But the phone rang in the kitchen and I heard it anyway, so it was fine. It was maybe one ring later.

In conclusion, I think that if you try keeping your phone in the kitchen for a week you will probably find that you don't really need it by the bed, and that you sleep better. I'm not saying everyone has to do it, but I think it's worth trying, and I think Odysseus would agree.

FINAL · 4 March 2028 · 496 words

My phone sleeps in the kitchen now. It has for seven months. People ask whether I miss it at night, and the honest answer is that I cannot remember what I was doing with it there, which is the whole argument.

The case for keeping a phone by the bed is built on one word: in case. In case someone calls. In case something happens. In case I wake at three and need to know the time, the surf, the news, the score. I kept the phone there for ten years on the strength of that word and it never once earned its keep. Nobody called. The things that happened waited until morning, as things do. And the three-a.m. check was never a check. It was an hour.

Odysseus knew what he was dealing with. He did not resolve to be strong when the Sirens sang. He had himself tied up beforehand, by people he trusted, and told them to ignore whatever he said once the singing started. The design assumed he would fail, and it worked because of that assumption, not in spite of it. The kitchen is my mast. The forty feet of hallway is the rope. At midnight I am not a person who can be trusted with a glowing rectangle, and I have stopped pretending otherwise.

Here is what changed. I sleep about forty minutes longer, by the watch I started wearing for the purpose. I read in bed, a paper book, which I had not done since I was sixteen. I wake up and lie there for a while, thinking about nothing in particular, which turns out to be where most of my ideas for the Workshop come from. The morning check still happens. It happens standing in the kitchen with coffee, and it takes four minutes, because standing is not a position you scroll in.

The objection is emergencies, so let me take it seriously. In seven months there has been one: my mother in the hospital at two in the morning. The call came to the kitchen. The kitchen is forty feet away. I heard it on the second ring, which is one ring later than I would have heard it from the nightstand. That is the entire cost of the mast, one ring, and I paid it gladly for two hundred nights of sleep.

I am not telling anyone to do this. I am telling you that the thing you are sure you need by the bed is something you have never once needed by the bed, and that the test is cheap: one week, forty feet, a book. If I am wrong you can have it back. You will not want it back.

What the line-edit took out: "I think that," "probably," "kind of," "basically," "in conclusion." What it put in: the watch, the forty feet, the one ring. The argument did not change. The sentences stopped apologising for it.